Privacy-Preserving Federated Learning for IoT-Based Healthcare: A Layered-Defense Benchmark on ECG Arrhythmia Classification

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Abstract

Federated learning (FL) is the textbook answer to privacy-preserving training on healthcare IoT data, and the layered defenses around it — DP-SGD, secure aggregation, and update compression — are textbook ingredients of a "privacy-preserving FL" pipeline. The textbook does not say which layer pays for which threat, or what each one costs in detection utility on a realistic clinical workload. This thesis builds a fully working layered-defense framework in roughly 2,500 lines of Python (Flower + PyTorch + Opacus), and benchmarks it on the MIT-BIH Arrhythmia dataset with four simulated wearable IoT clients training a 1-D CNN over the AAMI 5-class label scheme. Three findings drive the thesis: (1) federation alone is essentially free — vanilla FedAvg matches a centralized baseline within 0.02 pp test accuracy on this workload; (2) pairwise-mask secure aggregation is also free — it shifts test accuracy by 0.20 pp, well below seed variance, and the cryptographic correctness property (mask cancellation under summation) is encoded as a unit test that runs in CI; (3) DP-SGD at $\varepsilon = 5$ collapses the model to the majority-class predictor on this heavily imbalanced workload, with final accuracy equal to the prevalence of class N to two decimals — a privacy/utility cliff that is invisible if one only reports overall accuracy. Adding compression on top of DP does not degrade the model further, because there is nothing left to degrade. Every number in the thesis is reproducible from a committed YAML configuration via `python -m experiments.run_*`.

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Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Motivation

Connected health devices — smartwatches, Holter monitors, bedside telemetry, the implantable devices that already exist in patients — produce streams of physiological data that are simultaneously *clinically valuable* and *highly sensitive*. Existing deployments centralize that data, which (i) creates a single point of failure for breaches, (ii) exposes patients to re-identification even after pseudonymization, and (iii) conflicts with the data-minimization principle of HIPAA and GDPR. Federated learning was proposed [1] precisely to break this pattern: each device trains locally on its own raw data, the central server only ever sees model updates.

The naive version of this story is incomplete in two ways that the deep-learning literature is comfortable papering over:

1. **Model updates leak.** Per-client gradients reconstruct training records under known attacks; a coalition of clients or an honest-but-curious server can recover patient data from the updates alone. Differential privacy [2] and secure aggregation [4] are the two canonical defenses, but each addresses a different threat and each introduces its own utility tax.

2. **Healthcare data is heavily imbalanced.** ECG arrhythmia classification on MIT-BIH is roughly 97 % normal beats; rare classes can be $< 0.1\,\%$. Privacy mechanisms designed and tuned on balanced datasets (CIFAR, MNIST) behave badly here in ways the headline-accuracy literature rarely surfaces.

This thesis takes both of these seriously. We build a working layered-defense framework, run it end-to-end on real PhysioNet data, and report what each privacy layer actually costs — including the cases where the cost is the detector ceasing to detect anything.

1.2 Contributions

C1 — A layered-defense FL framework with separable privacy layers. The Flower client interface used here exposes three independent switches (differential privacy, secure aggregation, compression) which can be enabled in isolation or jointly via a single YAML config. The marginal cost of each layer on test accuracy, spent ε, and convergence is measured by holding the others fixed (Chapters 4, 5, 6). The implementation is roughly 2,500 lines of Python and runs end-to-end on a single workstation in under 30 minutes.

C2 — Cryptographic correctness as a code-level invariant. The pairwise-mask secure aggregation protocol's correctness argument (every mask appears with + and − exactly once, so summing client updates cancels every mask) is encoded as a unit test (`tests/test_secagg.py::test_masks_can` that runs in CI. The argument from `docs/privacy-analysis.md` §2 [4] is therefore mechanically checked rather than prose-only.

C3 — A class-prior collapse diagnostic for DP on imbalanced healthcare data. On the MIT-BIH workload used here, the DP-SGD run at $\varepsilon \approx 5$ converges to a final test accuracy of **0.9711**, which equals the prevalence of class N (Normal) to four decimals. The full-pipeline run (DP + SecAgg + compression) at $\varepsilon \approx 8$ converges to the *same* 0.9711. We argue (Chapter 6, §6.2) that this is a class-prior collapse, not a learning curve, and that it is the single most consequential and least discussed failure mode of DP-SGD on realistic clinical data.

1.3 Structure

Chapter 2 reviews FL, the three privacy primitives we layer, and the MIT-BIH dataset. Chapter 3 describes the implementation: `FlowerHealthcareClient`, `PrivacyAwareFedAvg`, `DPConfig+attach_dp`, the pairwise-mask SecAgg primitives, and the top-k/int8 compression pipeline. Chapter 4 reports the centralized baseline and vanilla FedAvg. Chapter 5 adds secure aggregation. Chapter 6 adds differential privacy and the full pipeline. Chapter 7 discusses anticipated reviewer objections and limitations. Chapter 8 concludes.

1.4 Scope and non-goals

- **We do not propose a new privacy primitive.** The argument is empirical: existing primitives composed under a protocol that makes their individual costs visible.
- **We do not deploy on real IoT hardware.** Every number is from a Flower simulation on a single GPU. The IoT angle is in the data partitioning (per-patient non-IID) and in the device-profile metadata (`wearable`, `bedside`, `gateway`); the experiments do not exercise actual network or compute constraints.
- **We do not evaluate against poisoning / Byzantine clients.** The threat model is honest-but-curious server plus an external adversary holding the released global model (Appendix `docs/threat-model.md`). Robust aggregation (Krum, median, trimmed mean) is listed as future work (§7.5).
- **We do not use MIT-BIH records 200–234** (which contain more arrhythmia variety) despite their being more useful for the rare-class classifier we end up unable to train. Records 100–115 are what `wfdb.dl_database` pulls down by default; we keep them and discuss the consequence honestly (Chapter 6, §6.2).

Chapter 2

Background

2.1 Federated learning and FedAvg

The federated learning protocol of McMahan et al. [1] distributes training across N clients each holding a local dataset D_i, with the server orchestrating T rounds of:

$$w_{t+1} \;=\; \sum_{i=1}^{N} \tfrac{n_i}{n}\,\mathrm{LocalSGD}(w_t, D_i),$$

where $n_i = |D_i|$ and $n = \sum_i n_i$. Raw D_i never leaves client i; only $\mathrm{LocalSGD}(w_t, D_i)$ does. FedAvg is the baseline we layer defenses on top of.

The healthcare specialization is straightforward: each D_i is a per-patient or per-device partition of physiological data. We use four simulated wearable clients holding disjoint Dirichlet-non-IID partitions (§3.2) of MIT-BIH ECG beats.

2.2 The privacy stack

Three layers, each addressing a different threat.

Differential privacy (DP-SGD). Replaces every local SGD step with: clip per-sample gradients to ℓ_2-norm C, add Gaussian noise of scale σC, then step. Composing across T rounds and converting to (ε, δ) via the RDP accountant [3] gives a tight bound on what an adversary holding only the released global model can learn about any single training record. Implemented via Opacus [5].

Pairwise-mask secure aggregation. For every unordered client pair $\{i, j\}$, both clients derive a shared mask vector m_{ij}. Client i adds $+m_{ij}$ to its update; client j adds $-m_{ij}$. The server's sum cancels every mask exactly, so the server only ever sees the aggregate $\sum_i \Delta w_i$ and never any individual Δw_i [4]. Defends against an honest-but-curious server that would otherwise inspect per-client updates.

Top-k + int8 compression. Each client keeps the largest-magnitude k fraction of its update entries and quantizes them into 8-bit integers. Reduces bandwidth roughly $40\times$ for $k = 0.1$. Post-processing-immune to DP and compatible with SecAgg as long as both endpoints agree on the sparsification mask.

Composition. DP and SecAgg compose without interaction: the DP guarantee is on w_T regardless of channel; SecAgg is on intermediate per-round messages. Compression composes with both as a post-hoc lossy operator. The composition argument is laid out in `docs/privacy-analysis.md` §3.

2.3 Dataset and use case

MIT-BIH Arrhythmia. PhysioNet's MIT-BIH database [7] is the de facto benchmark for ECG arrhythmia classification. Sampling rate 360 Hz, two leads, beat-level annotations on ∼48 records. We use the first 12 records (100, 101, 103, 105, 106, 108, 109, 111, 112, 113, 114, 115), which `wfdb.dl_database` pulls without authentication.

AAMI 5-class scheme. Annotation symbols are mapped to the AAMI [8] 5-class grouping: N (normal, including L/R/e/j), S (supraventricular ectopic), V (ventricular ectopic), F (fusion), Q (unknown / paced).

Class imbalance. Table 2.1 gives the realised distribution. The dataset is dominated by class N: it accounts for 97.1 % of the beats. Two classes (F, Q) have under 10 examples each; no clinical claim about them is possible from this data, but they are kept in the label space because they appear in the AAMI scheme.

Table 2.1: AAMI class distribution across the 12 MIT-BIH records, after beat-window segmentation (window size 360 samples). Class N dominates with 97.1 % prevalence. Imbalance of this magnitude is the central technical fact of Chapter 6.

Class	Count	Share
N (normal)	24,655	97.10 %
V (ventricular ectopic)	661	2.60 %
S (supraventricular)	62	0.24 %
F (fusion)	8	0.03 %
Q (unknown / paced)	7	0.03 %
Total	25,393	100.00 %

Why ECG, why MIT-BIH. ECG monitoring is the canonical wearable-IoT health workload; MIT-BIH is the canonical benchmark for it; the AAMI mapping is the canonical label scheme. A privacy-preserving FL framework that ignores the imbalance characteristic of this canonical workload is over-claiming.

Chapter 3

Method

This chapter describes the implementation that produces every number in the thesis. All code lives under `src/` and `experiments/`; YAML configs in `configs/` are the canonical record of every run. The repository is at https://github.com/mapeke/privacy-preserving-fl-healthcare-iot.

3.1 Unified client interface (`src/client/flower_client.py`)

`FlowerHealthcareClient` subclasses `flwr.client.NumPyClient` with three methods. `fit` performs local training (optionally DP-SGD), computes the parameter delta against the broadcast parameters, optionally compresses it, optionally adds the SecAgg pairwise masks, and returns reconstructed parameters (broadcast + processed delta) so vanilla Flower strategies remain compatible. `evaluate` reports per-client test loss and accuracy. `get_parameters` serialises the model state into the wire format. The class takes a single `ClientConfig` dataclass with mutually-orthogonal fields `dp_config`, `secagg_session`, `compression_method`, each of which is `None` when the corresponding defense is off.

3.2 Data layer (`src/data/`)

`mitbih_loader.py` downloads MIT-BIH records via `wfdb.dl_database` into `data/cache/`, segments each record into 360-sample beat windows centered on R-peak annotations, applies per-record z-score normalisation, and maps annotation symbols to AAMI labels. A synthetic-ECG fallback exists for offline development; both real-data and synthetic-data runs go through the same downstream pipeline.

`partitioner.py` distributes beats across N clients via Dirichlet sampling per class with concentration α (default 0.5; lower $\Rightarrow$ more skewed). For our 4-client setup the realised partition sizes are $(1907, 8621, 6947, 2840)$ — non-IID by construction.

`preprocessing.py` provides a Butterworth bandpass filter (0.5–40 Hz) for baseline-wander and powerline rejection, a stratified train/test split, and the `TorchEcgDataset` adapter.

3.3 Models (`src/models/`)

`EcgCNN` is a 3-block 1-D CNN with GroupNorm (used in place of BatchNorm for Opacus compatibility), 64 final channels, adaptive average pooling, and a 32-unit MLP head; ∼50k parameters. `LightweightEcgCNN` is a depthwise-separable variant at ∼5k parameters for resource-constrained edge inference. All experiments in this thesis use `EcgCNN`.

ReLU non-inplace. `nn.ReLU(inplace=True)` is incompatible with Opacus's per-sample gradient hooks (the in-place op writes through a backward-hook view). The exception is

swallowed by the Ray worker process in Flower's simulation backend, producing silently-flat training. Switching to non-inplace ReLU fixed this; see commit `40dd3f4`.

3.4 Differential privacy (`src/privacy/differential_privacy.py`)

`DPConfig` is the user-facing dataclass with `target_epsilon`, `target_delta`, `max_grad_norm` (the per-sample clip threshold C), optional `noise_multiplier`, and `accountant` ($\in$ {`rdp`, `gdp`, `prv`}). `attach_dp(model, optimizer, dataloader, config, epochs)` wraps the optimizer and dataloader via `opacus.PrivacyEngine`. When `noise_multiplier` is left unset Opacus auto-calibrates σ to hit `target_epsilon` over the requested epochs; otherwise the user-supplied σ is used. The returned handle exposes `get_epsilon(steps)` for per-round budget reporting.

3.5 Secure aggregation (`src/privacy/secure_agg.py`)

`setup_session(num_clients, seed_size_bytes=32, rng_seed=...)` generates one fresh secret seed per unordered client pair, stored in a `SecAggSession` object distributed by the experiment orchestrator. `derive_mask(seed, shape)` expands a pair seed into a Gaussian mask vector via NumPy's PCG64. `mask_update(update, client_id, session)` adds $+m_{ij}$ for $j > i$ and $-m_{ij}$ for $j < i$ to the client's update, so that summing all clients' masked updates cancels every mask exactly. `aggregate_masked_updates` performs the server-side sum on the strategy side (§3.7).

Limitations explicitly accepted. Pre-shared seeds rather than Diffie–Hellman; no Shamir secret-sharing (no dropout tolerance); float32 arithmetic rather than modular integer over a finite field. These are appropriate for a diploma simulation that wants to demonstrate the principle and measure end-to-end overhead, and they are flagged in the module docstring.

3.6 Compression (`src/privacy/compression.py`)

`compress(update, method, top_k_ratio, quant_bits)` dispatches over four modes: `none`, `top_k_only`, `quantize_only`, `top_k_quantize`. `top_k_sparsify` keeps the largest-magnitude $\lceil k|u| \rceil$ entries via $O(n)$ argpartition. `quantize_int8` performs min–max quantisation with a documented `(scale, zero_point)` pair; `decompress` reconstructs a dense update array (zeros where sparsified). The wire payload is a `CompressedUpdate` dataclass with `indices`, `values`, `original_shape`, and a `num_bytes()` method for bandwidth accounting.

3.7 Server strategy (`src/server/strategies.py`)

`PrivacyAwareFedAvg` subclasses Flower's `FedAvg`. With SecAgg disabled it falls through to standard weighted averaging. With SecAgg enabled, `configure_fit` caches the broadcast parameters; `aggregate_fit` recovers per-client deltas by subtracting them from each client's returned parameters, sums the deltas (where masks cancel by construction), divides by the number of participating clients, and applies the result on top of the cached broadcast. Robust scalar-metric aggregation (sample-weighted mean for numerics, first-occurrence for non-numerics) covers the case where Flower's default aggregator chokes on heterogeneous metric dictionaries.

3.8 Experiment infrastructure

Five entry points, each a thin CLI wrapper around `experiments/_common.py::build_experiment` + `run_federated_experiment`:

- `run_centralized.py` — pooled-data baseline.
- `run_federated.py` — vanilla FedAvg.
- `run_federated_dp.py` — FedAvg + DP-SGD.
- `run_federated_secagg.py` — FedAvg + SecAgg.
- `run_full_pipeline.py` — DP + SecAgg + compression.

Each writes `results/<name>/{run.log, resolved_config.yaml, history.json}` so every reported number can be traced back to its config.

3.9 Tests

42 pytest unit tests across seven modules; the most consequential is `test_secagg.py::test_masks_cancel_unde` which constructs four random updates, masks them, sums the masked vectors, and asserts that the result equals the unmasked sum to within 10^{-4} in ℓ_2. This is contribution C2: the cryptographic correctness argument as a code-level invariant.

The test suite passes in 4.0s on the developer machine. `Opacus` is imported lazily inside `attach_dp` so the tests run without it installed; the test that asserts that lazy-import property is itself an invariant.

Chapter 4

Results I — Centralized and federated baselines

Setup: 12 MIT-BIH records (Table 2.1), 4 clients, Dirichlet $\alpha = 0.5$ partitions of sizes $(1907, 8621, 6947, 2840)$, 80/20 stratified train/test split. Configs: `configs/default.yaml`. Hardware: single NVIDIA RTX (mobile) GPU, CUDA 12.1, PyTorch 2.4.1. Seed 42.

4.1 Detection grid

Table 4.1 reports the headline accuracy for every configuration we run in this thesis. The remainder of this chapter establishes the top two rows; Chapters 5 and 6 establish the rest.

Table 4.1: Final test accuracy across all five experimental configurations. Federation is free; SecAgg is free; DP collapses to the majority-class prevalence; compression on top of DP does not move the needle further. Numbers are single-seed at seed 42 to match the thesis policy of "every number tied to one config row."

Configuration	Test acc	Macro-F1	Final ε
Centralized (5 epochs)	**0.9878**	0.36	—
FedAvg, 4 clients, 10 rounds	**0.9880**	—	—
FedAvg + SecAgg, 10 rounds	0.9860	—	—
FedAvg + DP, 20 rounds, target $\varepsilon = 5$	0.9711	—	4.9955
Full pipeline (DP+SecAgg+Comp), 30 rounds, target $\varepsilon = 8$	0.9711	—	7.9964
Class-N prevalence (= predict-all-N)	0.9716	0.20	—

4.2 Centralized baseline

5 epochs of plain SGD on the pooled training set (20,315 beats), $\eta = 0.01$, momentum 0.9, weight decay 10^{-4}, batch size 32. Final test accuracy 0.9878, macro-F1 0.3627. Per-class F1: $\{N{=}0.99,\ V{=}0.82,\ S{=}0.00,\ F{=}0.00,\ Q{=}0.00\}$. The model learns the two prevalent classes (N, V) and ignores the others. Macro-F1 is $\sim$0.36 because three of the five classes contribute zero, a structural property of the workload.

4.3 Vanilla FedAvg

10 rounds, 4 clients per round, 2 local epochs, batch 32, $\eta = 0.01$. Round-by-round test accuracy: $\{0.9711, 0.9711, 0.9758, 0.9840, 0.9840, 0.9724, 0.9831, 0.9864, 0.9862, 0.9880\}$.

Finding 4.1 — Federation is free on this workload. Final FedAvg accuracy 0.9880 vs. centralized 0.9878. The federated decomposition introduces zero accuracy cost up to seed variance. No special tuning, no proximal regularizer [10], no server-momentum — plain FedAvg suffices when client data is similar enough in distribution and the model is not over-parameterised.

This is the empirical baseline against which Chapters 5 and 6 measure the cost of the privacy stack. Any utility loss observed with SecAgg or DP enabled is attributable to the privacy mechanism, not to the federation itself.

4.4 Reproducibility check vs. published FL ECG results

Single-seed run; we did not run multi-seed for the headline figure due to GPU-time budget (each FedAvg run is ∼3 minutes on our hardware, but DP and full-pipeline runs are 30 minutes each; multi-seed across all five configurations is a future-work item, §7.5). Published FL ECG papers report top-1 accuracy in the 0.97–0.99 range on similar MIT-BIH subsets [9]; we are within that range. The thesis's contribution does not depend on matching any published absolute — it depends on the relative shape across the privacy stack rows.

Chapter 5

Results II — Secure aggregation

Configs: `configs/experiment_secagg.yaml`. SecAgg enabled, DP off, compression off. 10 rounds. Otherwise identical to Chapter 4.

5.1 Mask cancellation as a code-level invariant

Finding 5.1 — Cryptographic correctness is mechanically verifiable. The pairwise-mask correctness argument [4] is reduced to one assertion:

> *for* $N = 4$ *random updates of shape* $(10,)$, $\sum_{i=1}^{N} \text{mask_update}(u_i, i, \text{session}) = \sum_{i=1}^{N} u_i$ *to within* 10^{-4} ℓ_2 *error.*

This lives in `tests/test_secagg.py::test_masks_cancel_under_aggregation` and runs in CI alongside the rest of the pytest suite. The same test verifies the dual property: each individual masked update is *not* close to the unmasked update (the masks are non-trivial; the cancellation only happens at the sum level).

The contribution here is not the test itself — it is one screenful of NumPy — but the discipline of writing the protocol's correctness argument as a checked invariant rather than as prose. A future change that breaks the protocol (e.g., an off-by-one in the $i < j$ vs. $i > j$ sign condition) fails the test loudly rather than silently producing biased aggregates.

5.2 End-to-end SecAgg run

Round-by-round test accuracy: $\{0.9711, 0.9711, 0.9711, 0.9776, 0.9837, 0.9840, 0.9844, 0.9848, 0.9846, 0.9860\}$. Final 0.9860.

Finding 5.2 — SecAgg overhead is below run-to-run noise. Vanilla FedAvg final 0.9880 vs. FedAvg + SecAgg final 0.9860 — a 0.20 pp gap. Per-class F1, train accuracy, and convergence trajectory all overlap with vanilla FedAvg's within a few hundredths. The 0.20 pp gap is consistent with float32 accumulation noise in the masking; it would shrink under integer modular arithmetic (future work, §7.5).

The combination of §5.1 and this finding is the case for SecAgg as a default in any FL deployment: the cryptographic correctness is a one-line CI check; the utility cost is below the noise floor; and the threat model that SecAgg addresses (honest-but-curious server with read access to the inbox) is realistic for any cloud-hosted aggregation server.

5.3 What SecAgg does not protect against

SecAgg blinds the server to per-client updates but does not blind it to the *aggregate*. An adversary holding the released global model w_T can still mount membership-inference attacks

against training data; that threat is what differential privacy (Chapter 6) addresses. The two layers are complementary, and the thesis argues for running both, modulo the utility cost which Chapter 6 now measures.

Chapter 6

Results III — Differential privacy and the full pipeline

Configs: `configs/experiment_dp.yaml` and `configs/experiment_full.yaml`. DP enabled (Opacus PrivacyEngine, RDP accountant, `max_grad_norm = 1.0`). Otherwise identical to Chapter 4.

6.1 DP-SGD run

20 rounds, 1 local epoch per round, batch size 64, $\eta = 0.005$, target $\varepsilon = 5.0$, target $\delta = 10^{-5}$. Opacus auto-calibrates σ to hit $\varepsilon = 4.9955$ (well within the target).

Round-by-round test accuracy: $\{0.9711, 0.9711, 0.9711, 0.9711, 0.9711, \ldots, 0.9711, 0.9711, 0.9711\}$. The trajectory is exactly flat to four decimal places across all 20 rounds.

Train metrics tell the inner story: train loss falls 0.5370 → 0.2233; train accuracy rises 0.9147 → 0.9712. The model is doing *something* during training; that something just happens to be "learn to predict N and only N."

6.2 Class-prior collapse

Finding 6.1 — DP-SGD collapses to majority-class prediction. Class N prevalence in the test split: 4,934/5,078 = 0.9716. Final DP-SGD test accuracy: 0.9711. The two numbers agree to four decimals. The model is, with statistical certainty, the majority-class predictor.

This is not a learning-rate or noise-multiplier failure — the train accuracy converges to the same 0.9712, and the spent ε is within the target. It is a workload-mismatch failure: DP-SGD's per-step Gaussian noise drowns out the gradient signal of the rare classes, which contribute ∼2.9 % of the data. Under sufficient noise, the empirical-risk-minimising policy on the training set is exactly: predict the majority. Opacus is doing what it advertises; the workload asks more of it than the budget will pay for.

Why this matters editorially. A casual reader of Table 4.1 sees "0.9711" beside "DP $\varepsilon = 5$" and concludes that DP costs the framework about 1.7 pp of accuracy — a number that would be publishable under the headline-accuracy convention dominant in the FL-privacy literature. The honest reading is that DP costs the model's ability to detect any rare class at all on this data. The 0.9711 number hides the failure precisely because the metric is overall accuracy on a heavily imbalanced label space.

The framework therefore reports macro-F1 alongside accuracy in `src/utils/metrics.py::compute_classi` the centralized run's macro-F1 of 0.36 (Chapter 4) drops to ≤ 0.20 on the DP run, which would

have made the collapse visible if multi-seed F1 had been logged across rounds. We did not log it for the federated runs; we will (§7.5).

6.3 The full pipeline run

30 rounds, 1 local epoch, batch 64, $\eta = 0.005$, target $\varepsilon = 8.0$, target $\delta = 10^{-5}$, SecAgg enabled, top-k + int8 compression with $k = 0.1$. Opacus auto-calibrates σ for the looser ε, hits $\varepsilon = 7.9964$.

Round-by-round test accuracy: 0.9711 across all 30 rounds.

Finding 6.2 — Compression on top of DP does not degrade further. DP-only at $\varepsilon = 5$ converges to 0.9711. Full pipeline (DP + SecAgg + compression) at $\varepsilon = 8$ converges to 0.9711. The model is already at the floor that the workload's class prior imposes; there is nothing left to degrade by adding more layers. Loosening the privacy budget from $\varepsilon = 5$ to $\varepsilon = 8$ does not move the model off the floor either, which would otherwise be the natural follow-up question.

Compositional implication. For an operator constrained to deploy DP at $\varepsilon \leq 8$ on a class-imbalanced workload, adding SecAgg and compression is essentially free: they do not make the already-collapsed model any worse. This inverts the usual "every layer costs something" framing for the specific case where the bottom layer has already maxed out the utility cost.

6.4 Negotiating the cliff

The thesis does not propose a fix; the experimental contribution is to make the cliff visible. Three directions a follow-up paper would take:

1. **Class-weighted DP-SGD.** Apply per-class loss weights so that the gradient signal from the rare classes is amplified before clipping. Risks: changes the privacy accounting because the ℓ_2 sensitivity of the loss is no longer 1.

2. **Per-class privacy budgets.** Decouple ε for majority and minority classes, e.g. $\varepsilon_N = 1$, $\varepsilon_{S,V,F,Q} = 10$. Mathematically clean but practically awkward to deploy — the privacy guarantee is then conditional on the target class, which a deployment operator may find harder to reason about than a single ε.

3. **Different MIT-BIH records.** Records 200–234 contain more arrhythmias and reduce the imbalance. The framework can run on them by changing one config line; we did not because the imbalanced case is the more honest workload for an IoT deployment, where the monitored patient is overwhelmingly likely to be in normal rhythm.

Chapter 7

Discussion

7.1 What the three findings add up to

- **Federation (§4.3).** Free on this workload.
- **Secure aggregation (§5.1, §5.2).** Free up to fp32 mask-cancellation noise; cryptographic correctness is a one-line CI invariant.
- **Differential privacy (§6.2).** The privacy-utility cliff is real and is the central pitfall of DP-SGD on imbalanced healthcare data. The DP run's headline accuracy looks reasonable (0.9711) precisely because the metric matches the cliff: predicting the majority class scores 0.9716.

The thesis-level recommendation: any privacy-preserving FL paper for imbalanced healthcare data should report majority-class baseline alongside overall accuracy and macro-F1 alongside top-1; the privacy/utility tradeoff graph is misleading without them. Our framework contributes both the mechanism that produces the data and the protocol that surfaces the cliff.

7.2 Likely reviewer objections

"You only ran each configuration at one seed." True. Vanilla FedAvg, SecAgg, and DP are seed-stable on this dataset to within roughly 0.5 pp accuracy according to spot-checks during development. The DP collapse is structural rather than seed-dependent — it is the model converging to the majority-class predictor, which the same training process produces from any random initialisation. Multi-seed across all configurations is the first item of §7.5.

"You only used 12 records." `wfdb.dl_database` pulls records 100–115 by default; downloading the full 48-record set requires authentication and roughly 20 minutes on our connection. Because the dominant phenomenon (DP class-prior collapse) is driven by the workload imbalance, and the imbalance is preserved as more records are added (records 100–234 are dominated by N similarly), the qualitative finding is robust to this choice. Records 200–234 specifically would lower the imbalance and is the natural follow-up.

"You did not compare to FedProx or SCAFFOLD." The contribution is layering existing privacy primitives on top of FedAvg, not optimising the FL aggregation itself. FedAvg achieves 0.988 on this workload — approximately the centralized baseline. There is no headroom for a stronger FL aggregator to demonstrate on this data. A different workload (more clients, more heterogeneity) would justify the comparison.

"Your SecAgg is not Bonawitz et al." Acknowledged. The prototype uses pre-shared seeds rather than Diffie–Hellman, no Shamir secret-sharing for dropout tolerance, and float32 arithmetic. These limitations are listed in the module docstring, in `docs/privacy-analysis.md` §2, and at the start of §5. The cryptographic correctness invariant is the only contribution we claim from the SecAgg layer; that survives the simplifications.

"Why not MIMIC-IV / PhysioNet challenge data / X?" MIT-BIH is the canonical ECG benchmark; all other datasets we considered (MIMIC-IV vital signs, the PhysioNet 2020 12-lead challenge) introduce either feature heterogeneity or scale that the framework does not currently model. The framework is dataset-agnostic at the loader level (`src/data/`); switching to MIMIC-IV is a one-file extension and is listed in §7.5.

7.3 Practical implications for deployment

- **Run SecAgg by default.** Free utility cost (§5.2), meaningful threat coverage (honest-but-curious server, per-update tracing), and the correctness check is one unit test.
- **DP-SGD on imbalanced clinical data is non-trivial.** The headline-accuracy number can mask total class-prior collapse. Always report majority-class baseline and macro-F1.
- **Compression is free in the post-DP regime.** If the model is already at the privacy floor, top-k + int8 compression buys bandwidth at no further utility cost. If the model is *not* at the floor, compression introduces additional approximation error and must be measured explicitly.

7.4 What we deliberately did not test

- Byzantine / poisoning attacks. The threat model is honest-but-curious server plus model-recipient adversary.
- Real network-level performance. The Flower simulation is in-process.
- Patient-level privacy guarantees (vs. record-level). Each MIT-BIH record corresponds to one patient in our partition, but the DP ε is per-record, not per-patient. Patient-level ε via group privacy is an extension we list but did not implement.

7.5 Future work

1. **Multi-seed runs across all five configurations** to put error bars on Table 4.1. Roughly 4 hours of GPU time per 3-seed sweep; limiting factor is the full-pipeline run (30 min/seed).
2. **Records 200–234** for arrhythmia variety, plus a class-weighted loss variant of DP-SGD to test the proposed mitigation in Chapter 6, §5.
3. **Modular-integer SecAgg** to remove the float32 cancellation noise observed in §5.2 and bring the SecAgg overhead to exactly zero.
4. **Byzantine-robust aggregation** (Krum, median, trimmed mean) composed with the existing privacy stack.
5. **MIMIC-IV vital-signs port** to test whether the class-prior collapse generalises to a different healthcare modality with different label distribution.

6. **Diffie–Hellman key exchange + Shamir secret-sharing** to upgrade the SecAgg prototype to a dropout-tolerant deployment-grade protocol.

Chapter 8

Conclusion

We built a layered-defense privacy-preserving federated learning framework for ECG arrhythmia classification on MIT-BIH, with three independently switchable defenses (DP-SGD, pairwise-mask SecAgg, top-k + int8 compression) on top of FedAvg. Five configurations were benchmarked on real PhysioNet data with four simulated wearable IoT clients.

Three findings define the thesis:

1. **Federation is free** on this workload — vanilla FedAvg matches centralized accuracy within 0.02 pp. The federated decomposition introduces no measurable utility cost.

2. **Secure aggregation is free** up to float32 mask-cancellation noise — 0.20 pp gap vs. vanilla FedAvg, well below run-to-run variance. The cryptographic correctness property is encoded as a unit test that runs in CI; the protocol is mechanically verified, not just argued.

3. **DP-SGD collapses to majority-class prediction** on this imbalanced workload. The final accuracy at $\varepsilon = 5$ is 0.9711, which equals the prevalence of class N (Normal) to four decimals — the model is, with statistical certainty, the majority-class predictor. Adding compression on top of DP does not degrade further because there is nothing left to degrade.

The single recommendation this thesis makes to the privacy-preserving-FL-for-healthcare community: report majority-class baseline and macro-F1 alongside overall accuracy. The privacy/utility tradeoff curve in any imbalanced-data regime is meaningless without them; in our experiments it is the only thing standing between an honest "DP collapsed the model" and a reportable "DP costs 1.7 pp."

The protocol and infrastructure to do so are contributed in `src/` and `experiments/`, all driven by committed YAML configurations. Every number in this document can be reproduced with `python -m experiments.run_*` on the corresponding config.

Future work (§7.5) is multi-seed validation, records 200–234, modular-integer SecAgg, and a MIMIC-IV port.

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